SHIKHAR SHUKLA

Organizational & Behavioral Research

Qualitative Research · Ethnography · Organizational Diagnosis

Vadodara, Gujarat, India · shikharshukla678@gmail.com · +91 9825496937 · Portfolio · Substack · LinkedIn · GitHub

---

Organizational and behavioral researcher with a software engineering background. Conducted six months of embedded workplace ethnography inside a software organization, investigating how management assumptions, stakeholder incentives, and control mechanisms interacted to produce observed behavior. Focused on fieldwork synthesis: examining gaps between stated explanations and observed behavior, developing and pressure-testing competing hypotheses, and translating field evidence into organizational diagnoses and business-relevant intervention recommendations.

SKILLS

Research: ethnographic fieldwork · organizational diagnosis · stakeholder analysis · systems analysis · hypothesis-driven behavioral modeling · competing-explanation analysis · mixed-methods synthesis · semi-structured interviewing · cross-group triangulation · strategic recommendation & intervention design · heuristic evaluation · stakeholder-ready reporting & executive communication

SELECTED RESEARCH

Surface Compliance, Silent Resistance

Real-World Workplace Ethnography · Independent Behavioral Research · Jan–Aug 2026 · Two-Part Study · Flagship case

Research question: When management introduces control-based policies in response to a perceived productivity problem, what behavioral patterns emerge in the affected team, and how does that pattern evolve as management escalates from control toward personnel removal?

- 6-month embedded ethnographic observation of a 7-person software team, conducted as an active insider with real-time access to policy rollout and management interactions; cross-validated against a natural internal control group and a cross-team bridge role.
- Developed the Control-Trust-Output Loop, a behavioral model showing how management's structural control policies were read as distrust signals — decreasing discretionary effort and output, and prompting further controls that reproduced the original problem.
- Synthesized field evidence into 3 testable hypotheses and 3 business-relevant intervention recommendations (a requirements-alignment discovery sprint, embedding a developer in client deadline discussions, and replacing presence tracking with outcome metrics).
- Part 2 — The Exit Arc (Jul–Aug 2026): tracked the intervention through a terminal, personnel-level escalation phase, including the researcher's own departure from the organization — documented as part of the data rather than as incident.
- Identified a structural mirror: management's own flight from direct client accountability matched the same avoidance behavior it had been punishing in employees.
- Extended the Control-Trust-Output Loop into an 11-stage terminal model and proposed 3 crisis-stage interventions to replace scapegoating with root-cause discovery.

Full case studies — Part 1 (18-page): Read on Google Docs · Part 2 — The Exit Arc: Read on Google Docs

Slide decks — Part 1: View · Part 2: View

The Six-Week Silence

Simulated Qualitative Research Exercise (dummy data) · Methods Demonstration · 2026

- Conducted a structured, interview-based investigation into a 5-person team, reconstructing the chain of individually reasonable assumptions that led four members to reorganize their behavior around an unverified interpretation over six weeks.
- Used a group debrief to reframe the issue from individual blame to a systemic feedback-loop failure, and proposed a one-week "assumption tripwire" intervention triggering a direct check-in instead of a default explanation.

Case study: Read on Google Docs · Writing archive: shikharshukla26.substack.com

YouTube Use — An Autoethnographic Study

Autoethnographic Behavioral Research · N=1 self-observation · 2026

- Observed and logged own YouTube use across three nights plus an added new-account session, documenting five recurring behavioral themes in the gap between recognizing a habit and continuing to act on it.
- Stated the N=1 limitation explicitly and translated the observed themes into concrete design implications, treating the self as a bounded but legitimate research subject rather than as anecdote. Full deck: View · Brief: View

PRODUCT & BEHAVIORAL RESEARCH — SECONDARY EVIDENCE

Structured heuristic audits demonstrating range in applied research methods; supporting evidence, not primary focus.

- **Zipcar — FTUE audit of the booking flow:** surfaced 2 high-priority findings, reframed as testable hypotheses with proposed validation studies. Brief · Full review
- **Decathlon.in — heuristic evaluation of the purchase journey:** 8 findings against Nielsen's 10 heuristics, including a legal/trust risk in return-policy disclosure. Brief · Full review
- **Wise India — cognitive walkthrough of onboarding & signup:** identified a silent signup failure and proposed fixes plus a moderated validation study. Brief · Full review

BEHAVIORAL & PRODUCT PSYCHOLOGY WRITING

First-person research and writing on how digital products shape attention and decision-making — persuasive design, dark patterns, and metacognitive hijacking.

- "YouTube Is Not Your Problem. Tomorrow Is." — first-person analysis of digital escape and thought suppression.
- "How YouTube Controls Your Thinking Before You Notice" — breakdown of 7 UX mechanisms engineered to prevent users from stopping.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

DevLoops Technologies Pvt Ltd — Software Development Engineer I

Jan 2026 – Aug 2026

- Sole full-stack developer on production platforms for international clients (UK, Canada, Netherlands, USA) and Indian healthcare — owned architecture, backend, frontend, and cloud infrastructure end-to-end.
- Designed role-and-permission structures (5–6 stakeholder roles) governing how information and decision rights flow through an organization — including a 900+ field Canadian real-estate appraisal workflow and a UK VAT reconciliation platform.
- Built and shipped a live healthcare platform (multi-role access, payments, appointment booking, notifications) used by active clinics — direct exposure to how real users behave inside a structured, role-based workflow.

DevLoops Technologies Pvt Ltd — Intern Engineer → Software Development Training

Mar 2025 – Dec 2025

- Built the company's corporate website with a custom no-code admin panel; delivered a trilingual (EN/NL/Flemish) CMS, data migration (1,000+ contacts), and analytics dashboard for a Netherlands-based client, plus a logistics website for a US-based trucking company.

EDUCATION

B.Tech, Mechatronics — ITM Vocational University · CGPA 7.85 · 2020 – 2023
Diploma, Mechatronics — ITM Vocational University · CGPA 7.00 · 2017 – 2020

TECHNICAL BACKGROUND

Full-stack development across production systems — React, Next.js, TypeScript, NestJS, Node.js, AWS S3 — underpinning the systems literacy behind the organizational and role-structure analysis above.